

Bandwagons are the real problems. Not just that a bunch of top manufacturers jump onto them all at once, but the fact that they're forced to, because all of us buy into whatever bandwagon is trending at the moment. If Apple's making billions off you for touch, do you really expect the others to ignore touch and try something different?

Touch was new, and exciting, and did away with pesky keyboards and tiny screens. We loved it because as any other bratty baby, we also wanted to paw at stuff. We wanted to participate with a phone's screen instead of holding it up and staring at it. Older interfaces seemed primitive in comparison, because although on a PC we were so used to the dexterity of a mouse, on mobile devices, cursors and selections were a pain. It's just so much easier to tap on what you see than use a scroll and button combination, right?

However, the real problem is, touch isn't an innovation in UI design, it's just another way of doing the same old things. How radically different is tapping on an icon as compared to clicking on one with a mouse? Changing the input method is not really changing the UI – because you still need to scan a bunch of stuff on a screen, locate the one you want (swipe through pages of icons) and then select the one you want (click, touch, tap, whatever).

This is ideal when “browsing” for ideas, like with the old Start Menu on Windows. It was great for people wanting to figure out what they wanted to do. With newer versions of Windows we saw that same Start Menu get more organised, more search-based, because more and more people knew exactly what they wanted to do, and just wanted a quick way to start doing it.

Increasingly, technology is becoming a background tool. You might want to quickly start up your PC and start researching for an article or thesis you're writing, or you may just want to fire up Angry Birds on your phone to pop some pigs – regardless, you are now pretty sure of what you want to do with all of your computing devices. Even new apps rarely take more than a day for you to figure out; contrast this with a decade ago when getting a new PC or loading a new OS had a significant learning curve associated with it.

The problem with interfaces today, is that they're mostly touch-based. Very few seem to be pushing away from that, and perhaps that's because very few of us want



Closing running apps in iOS 7 is actually more painful

anything different for the moment. However, touch just doesn't cut it. In fact, some of the innovations seem to be digressing a bit when they attempt to improve.

Take iOS 7 (the developer versions, as of writing this), where the old way of closing background programs has been changed. All you had to do was to double-tap the home screen, the running apps bar would appear, hold down any icon till they start shaking, use the little close buttons on the top left of every icon to close them one at a time. Anyone who's given their iPad to a kid will tell you, when you get it back from them, you find scores of running programs open, which can be irritating to scroll through to find your list of apps.

With iOS 6.x and earlier, all you had to do was the steps we mentioned above, and then tap like 40 times in the same place (usually the running app on the extreme left) and you closed everything. With iOS 7 (so far) this has been changed to a swipe up motion. Sure the animation looks cooler, but sometimes when you're trying to swipe up the touch sensitivity thinks you're trying to go left or right, and scrolls through running apps instead. What we'd have really liked is a small counter here that told you how many apps were open, and maybe a Close All button or action. Yes you can use multi-touch to swipe up with up to 3 fingers to close up to 3 apps at a time in iOS 7, but it's still irritating and tiring to swipe up to close 30+ running apps. We actually prefer the BlackBerry 10 way, where you swipe up once to see running apps, and then just close the

ones you don't want, but then that platform has its own share of problems... as does every other platform.

Coming back to the point, touch is still just an implementation of the old way of doing things. Replacing a mouse with a finger – Control + Scroll with pinch, clicks with taps and scrollbars and other actions with various swipes and gestures. It's still an icon-based UI, which is the way it's been for more than three decades now.

So what are some of the possibilities that are being worked on or have been attempted? Let's take a look at some problems and the innovations that are trying to solve them. Some innovations are still within the touch-world, and some are truly new ways of doing things.

Keyboards

Whether you like it or not, text is here to stay for quite a while longer. It loads quickly on a page, is a nice silent communication method, and is what you're reading right now. Why? Because it's still a damn good way to convey content and ideas. It's when you get into the 5Cs (see page 1), and realise that three of them – Consume, Create and Communicate – still rely heavily on text, that you realise that keyboards are still important. However, typing is the bane of every touch device user. Even if you don't type a lot, you still could use a better more accurate way to do it.

We were recently contacted about a product called TREWgrip, which is basically a keyboard for touchscreen devices, but with a difference. Instead of killing your thumbs while typing, TREWgrip placed the keys under the device, so you use your fingers to type and hold the device, and your thumbs only to balance and grip. We're reserving judgement on the product until we see and use it, but it's an interesting example of innovative thinking. Interestingly, even if you're the kind of per-



TREWgrip allows you to type more ergonomically